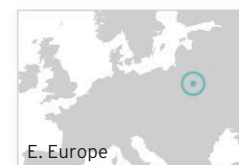


The Białowieża Forest

The only old-growth forest in lowland Europe and a refuge for the largest population of free-ranging European bison



Covering more than 580 square miles (1,500 square km), the Białowieża Forest is shared between Poland and Belarus. It is the only large remnant of the primeval forest that once covered northeastern Europe after the last ice age and is still home to some of the continent's tallest trees; old-growth spruce reaches more than 165 ft (50 m) here. Part of the Central European mixed-forest ecoregion that extends from

eastern Germany to northeastern Romania, Białowieża contains tree species from both northern (boreal) and lowland mixed deciduous forests. The latter include English oaks—some of which are thought to be 150–500 years old—as well as the small-leaved linden and hornbeam. Mixed broadleaf and conifer stands are also interspersed with pocket ecosystems, such as the increasingly rare boreal spruce bog forest.



◀ STRIPED COATS

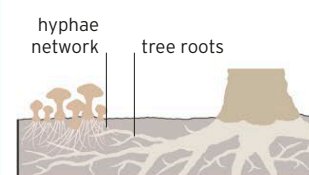
Wild boar young, known as boarlets or piglets, have striped coats to blend in with their dappled woodland surroundings.

Dead wood, new life

A high percentage of standing and fallen deadwood supports thousands of fungi, insects, and bird species, including the protected three-toed woodpecker. Wild boars, elks, wolves, and lynxes are common forest residents, and Białowieża is an important refuge for the continent's largest mammal, the European bison or wisent, with the largest free-ranging herd of this species.

TREES AND FUNGI

Many trees and fungi share a mutually beneficial relationship called a mycorrhiza. A fungus sends out hundreds of thin, rootlike threads called hyphae that grow around a tree's rootlets, absorbing sugars from them. In return, the tree uses the hyphae network to absorb more nutrients from the soil.



SWAMPY SANCTUARY

The Białowieża Forest contains several different habitats, including sections of spruce bog forest that are home to many rare plant species.